

THE **gathering**

SIX WEEKS IN PHILIPPIANS

Joy Unshakeable

AGES 8 TO 12

*Deeper teaching. Bigger questions.
Real answers.*

The Gathering Kids

THE GATHERING CTX • CLEBURNE, TEXAS

For our partners, with gratitude

WHAT IS INSIDE

Six weeks. One letter. One very happy prisoner.

WEEK 1

Joy in Chains

Philippians 1:1 to 30

WEEK 2

The Mind That Emptied Itself

Philippians 2:1 to 11

WEEK 3

Work It Out, Walk It Out

Philippians 2:12 to 30

WEEK 4

All Things Loss

Philippians 3:1 to 11

WEEK 5

Press On: Citizens of Heaven

Philippians 3:12 to 21

WEEK 6 PARTNER EDITION • FIRST PRINTING, AUGUST 2026 • MADE
FOR THE PARTNERS OF THE GATHERING CTX • NOT FOR SALE

The Settled Heart

Philippians 4:1 to 23

Joy in Chains

PHILIPPIANS 1:1 TO 30

Joy is not the reward for getting out of the prison, it is the settled confidence that the God who began a good work in you will finish it.

MEMORY VERSE

And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 1:6

Hey. This one is written just for you. Paul wrote this letter from a jail cell and somehow could not stop talking about joy. That is not normal. By the end of this week, you will understand why. Let's go.

God Never Abandons a Project He Started

And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 1:6

Paul is writing this from a prison cell. He is chained to a Roman guard. His trial could end in execution. And his first move is to thank God for the people at Philippi and tell them how sure he is that God is going to finish what He started in them. Not what Paul started. What God started. There is a huge difference.

He is not certain of his own release. He is not certain of a good verdict. He is certain of this one thing: God finishes what He begins. And Paul can say that because he lived it. He and his friend Silas were once thrown into a Philippian jail, beaten and bleeding, feet in stocks at midnight. And they sang. Not because they were okay with it. Because they knew God was still in it.

Your struggles right now are not evidence that God gave up on you. They are proof that He is still working. Chiseling. Shaping. Not finished yet.

Joy is not the reward for getting out of prison. Joy is what carried Paul while he was still in it. The praise came before the earthquake, and what it opened was a jailer's heart.

ἐπιτελέω (epiteleo), to complete, to finish what was started

Used in the ancient world for completing a sacrifice or finishing a construction project. God is not a contractor who abandons the job halfway. He is the master builder who sees every project through. Paul also uses this word in Galatians 3:3: having begun by the Spirit, are you now being perfected by the flesh? The answer is no. What the Spirit begins, the Spirit finishes. The completion was never your performance catching up to His beginning.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Paul was certain of God's faithfulness, not his own circumstances. What is a situation in your life where you need to trust God's faithfulness more than what you can see?
2. Paul and Silas sang at midnight before the miracle came. Is there a praise that needs to come before the thing you are waiting for?
3. If God finishes what He begins in you, what does that mean for the hard things you are walking through right now?

Then say this out loud. God began a good work in me and He will bring it to completion. My struggles are not evidence He gave up. They are proof He is still at work.

PRAY TOGETHER

God, thank You that You started this and You are the One who finishes it. I trust You with the parts of me that are not done yet. Amen.

Your Chains Can Advance Something You Cannot See

I want you to know, brothers, that what has happened to me has really served to advance the gospel, so that it has become known throughout the whole imperial guard and to all the rest that my imprisonment is for Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 1:12 TO 13

Paul reframes everything. The world says: Paul is stuck. Paul says: the gospel is advancing. The world says: this is a tragedy. Paul says: this is a strategy. A Roman soldier rotated shifts chained to Paul's wrist. Every few hours, a new guard. For hours, he listened to Paul pray, talk about Jesus, receive visitors, sing. Guard after guard. The gospel was spreading through Rome's most elite military unit. Not in spite of the chains. Because of them.

Think about who the Praetorian Guard were. Rome's elite. Connected to Caesar himself. No strategy, no invitation, no platform would have put the gospel in that room. But chains did. God does not waste your chains. Whatever confinement you are in right now: a hard family season, a school situation you cannot escape, a health thing you did not choose. It may be exactly the environment God is using to reach someone who could not be reached any other way.

God does not waste your chains. The very thing meant to silence you may be the vehicle He uses to reach someone else.

προκοπή (prokope), advancement, progress, forward movement

Used for a military advance, cutting through obstacles to move forward. Paul sees his imprisonment not as a setback but as a strategic advance. The gospel is cutting through barriers it never could have penetrated any other way. And Paul uses this same word again in verse 25 for the Philippians' own progress. His suffering and their growth are one story. His chains are producing their prokope.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What feels like a chain in your life right now? What might God be advancing through that specific confinement?
2. Paul's boldness in chains made other believers bolder in verse 14. Who has become braver because of how you have handled something hard?
3. The Praetorian Guard would never have heard the gospel without Paul's imprisonment. Who in your life is in a position that only your specific difficulty can reach?

Then say this out loud. My chains are advancing the gospel. What the enemy meant to confine me, God is using to reach someone I cannot reach any other way.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, I do not like this hard thing, but I trust You with it. Use it to reach somebody only it can reach. Amen.

To Live Is Christ. To Die Is Gain. Do the Math.

For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain.

PHILIPPIANS 1:21

Paul could be executed. Caesar could sign the order. The sword could fall. And Paul looks at that possibility and says: either way, I win. That is either the most reckless thing anyone has ever said or the most free. Paul is not reckless. He is doing math.

The phrase to live is Christ is deeper than it looks. In the Greek, he writes to *zen Christos*. Literally: the living is Christ. Not I live for Christ, as though Christ were just the thing he is aiming at. Christ is the content of the living. The life itself is Christ expressed through him. Compare that with Galatians 2:20: it is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me. Union. Not imitation. Big difference.

Here is the question Paul forces you to sit with: what do you have to be threatened with? If your identity is truly in Christ, what can anyone take from you? Your reputation? Your comfort? Your health? Paul has run the numbers. When death itself is gain, nothing lesser can threaten you. When Christ is your life, no one can take what matters most. That is not bravado. That is math.

What do you threaten a person with when death itself is gain? Paul discovered the answer and it unlocked a freedom no chain could hold.

κέρδος (kerdos), gain, profit, advantage

A commercial term used for financial profit. Paul is doing resurrection math: if I die, I gain. I come out ahead. Death for the believer is not loss. It is the moment you receive in full what you have only tasted in part. If to live is participation in the life of Christ, then death does not end the life. It perfects it. The veil of this body removed. The union complete. Unmediated.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. There is a difference between working hard for someone you admire and living with someone who is right there with you. Which one is closer to how you experience Jesus most days?
2. If to live is Christ and to die is gain, what specific thing that is currently threatening your peace loses its power?
3. Paul chose to stay for the sake of others, not himself. Who in your life is the reason God has you here right now?

Then say this out loud. For me to live is Christ and to die is gain. I cannot be threatened. When death itself is gain, nothing lesser holds power over me.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, You are my life, not just my helper. Take the fear out of me and put Your freedom in its place. Amen.

Your Citizenship Is Not from Here

Only let your manner of life be worthy of the gospel of Christ, so that whether I come and see you or am absent, I may hear of you that you are standing firm in one spirit, with one mind striving side by side for the faith of the gospel, and not frightened in anything by your opponents.

PHILIPPIANS 1:27 TO 28

The word Paul uses for manner of life here would have hit the Philippians in a specific place. They lived in a Roman colony. Roman citizenship was everything. It defined how you dressed, how you spoke, what rights you had, how you carried yourself. Paul picks that word on purpose.

Striving side by side is a military image. Soldiers with shields locked, advancing together, protecting each other. This is not solo Christianity. This is a team that holds the line together.

And then: not frightened in anything by your opponents. Feeling afraid is not the same as failing. Even brave people feel it. But standing steady while you feel it, that says something loud. It tells everyone watching that Someone bigger than the thing scaring you is holding you up. And that steadiness is not something you have to manufacture. God supplies it. Paul says so two verses later. Courage, steady and Spirit rooted, is a witness all by itself. And here is the one nobody celebrates: verse 29. It has been granted to you to suffer for His sake. Granted is *charizomai*. The grace word. Suffering for Christ is not a punishment. It is a grace given.

Courage is a witness. When you stand steady in front of the thing that scares you, you are preaching a sermon that no words can match.

πολιτεύομαι (*politeuomai*), to live as a citizen, to conduct yourself according to your citizenship

Roman citizens in Philippi carried themselves differently because of who they belonged to. Paul is saying: you are citizens of heaven. Live like it. Your primary allegiance is not to your school, your friend group, your social status, or any earthly kingdom. He returns to this in 3:20 with the noun *politeuma*: our citizenship is in heaven. This is not a single illustration he uses once. Paul is building a sustained argument across the whole letter.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. If your citizenship is in heaven, how should that change the way you carry yourself at school tomorrow?
2. Who are you striving side by side with? Is there someone you need to lock shields with this week?
3. Where has fear been running the show lately? What would standing steady look like in that specific situation?

Then say this out loud. I am a citizen of heaven and I carry myself like it. I am not frightened by my opponents. I stand firm, striving side by side with my people.

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, I belong to Your kingdom first. Give me steady courage where I have been shaky, and give me people to stand with. Amen.

I Will Rejoice. Yes, and I Will Rejoice.

What then? Only that in every way, whether in pretense or in truth, Christ is proclaimed, and in that I rejoice. Yes, and I will rejoice.

PHILIPPIANS 1:18

Read that again slowly. People are preaching Christ specifically to make Paul's imprisonment worse. He is chained to guards. He is awaiting a verdict that could go either way. And Paul says: I rejoice. Then he says it again. Yes, and I will rejoice. Twice. Deliberate. Like he is making sure it lands.

This is not positivity. This is not ignoring the hard stuff. This is a man who has found something so stable, so beyond the reach of any earthly development, that he can rejoice regardless of what Rome does next. Biblical joy is not emotion produced by favorable circumstances. It is a settled orientation of the whole person toward God in Christ.

Pull back and see the whole of chapter 1. God completes what He begins. Your chains advance the gospel. To live is Christ and to die is gain. Live as a citizen of heaven with unshaken courage. Every one of those is a pillar under the same roof: a joy that does not depend on circumstances because it does not come from them. That is the kind of Christianity that turns the world upside down. And it begins here. In a cell. With a man who cannot stop giving thanks.

Joy is not the absence of suffering. Joy is the presence of Christ in the midst of suffering.

χαίρω (chairō), to rejoice

Paul uses this verb twice in this one verse. I rejoice. Yes, and I will rejoice. Together with its noun form chara, meaning joy, these words appear sixteen times across this short letter. Paul deploys them from a prison cell, in the face of possible execution, surrounded by opposition. Biblical joy is not an emotion produced by good circumstances. It is a settled orientation of the whole

person toward God in Christ, available regardless of what the world is doing around you. The Philippians are not being asked to feel better. They are being called to a joy that no circumstance can reach.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. After five days in Philippians 1: which movement hit closest to something you are actually walking through right now?
2. Paul says I will rejoice twice. Joy is a choice, not just a feeling. What does choosing joy look like for you this specific week?
3. The church in Philippi was born in a river baptism and a prison shaking. What impossible place in your life might become the birthplace of something God is building?

Then say this out loud. He who began a good work in me will bring it to completion. My chains are advancing the gospel. For me to live is Christ and to die is gain. I cannot be threatened. I am a citizen of heaven. I have joy that circumstances cannot steal.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, I choose joy today, not because everything is easy but because You are here. Settle my heart on You. Amen.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

He who began a good work in me will bring it to completion.

I am a citizen of heaven and I have joy that circumstances cannot steal.

I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen.

The Mind That Emptied Itself

PHILIPPIANS 2:1 TO 11

Jesus was fully God and chose to go all the way down on purpose, so you can stop grabbing for status and start serving from a place that is already secure.

MEMORY VERSE

Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus.

PHILIPPIANS 2:5

Hey. This one is written just for you. The most powerful Person in the universe had every right to the highest place in everything, and He chose to go all the way down. On purpose. That should not make sense. By the end of this week you will see why it was the strongest move anybody has ever made. Let's go.

Since, Not If

So if there is any encouragement in Christ, any comfort from love, any participation in the Spirit, any affection and sympathy, complete my joy by being of the same mind, having the same love, being in full accord and of one mind.

PHILIPPIANS 2:1 TO 2

Paul heard that the church in Philippi looked fine on the outside and was cracking on the inside. Not a huge scandal. Something quieter. People competing. Comparing. Making sure everybody knew who mattered most. So Paul starts fixing it, and he does not start with a rule. He starts by reminding them what they already have.

Read that little word if again. Paul is not wondering whether these things are true. He writes it as a settled fact and builds on it. There is encouragement in Christ. There is comfort from love. The Holy Spirit really is in you. Paul is not asking a question he is unsure about. He is laying a foundation. All of that is already true about you.

Here is why the order matters so much. People fight to be important when they are not sure they already are. When you know you are loved, you stop needing to win the room. Paul is saying you have already been filled all the way up. Now let it spill over onto each other.

You do not fight for a seat when you already know you have one. Loved people can afford to be kind.

κοινωνία (koinonia), sharing something together, partnership, life held in common

When Paul says any participation in the Spirit, the word is koinonia. It does not mean you and God trade messages once in a while. It means you share the same life. The same Holy Spirit who lives in every other believer lives in you, right now. That is why Paul can ask these people to get along. They are not strangers who

agreed to be polite. They already share one life, and Paul is asking them to act like it.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. When do you feel the strongest need to prove that you matter?
2. What is something you already have in Jesus that you sometimes forget is yours?
3. Who is one person you could pour some of that overflow onto this week?

Then say this out loud. I already have encouragement in Christ. I am already loved. I do not have to win the room to matter.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, thank You that I am already Yours before I do one single thing. Fill me up until it spills over onto the people around me. Amen.

Humility Is Not Thinking Less of You

Do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves.

PHILIPPIANS 2:3

The Romans had a name for the ladder everybody was climbing. They called it the *cursus honorum*, the course of honors. You earned honor in public, you showed it off, and you defended it. Being made low was the worst thing that could happen to a person. Philippi was a Roman colony packed with retired soldiers who had climbed that ladder for a living. They knew the game, and they were still playing it inside the church.

Notice what Paul does not say. He does not say think you are worthless. He does not tell you to pretend you are bad at something you are actually good at. He says count others more significant. You can only do that if you are already secure. A kid who is not sure he matters has no room left for anybody else. A kid who knows he belongs to God has room for everybody.

Humility is not thinking less of yourself. It is thinking of yourself less. And that only works when you already know Whose you are.

ταπεινοφροσύνη (tapeinophrosune), humility, lowliness of mind

In Rome, words in this family were insults. Being low meant being nobody. A doormat. A groveler. A person with no worth. Paul grabs the insult and turns it into a badge of honor. Real humility is not believing you are junk. It is seeing yourself accurately in front of God, knowing you received everything and earned none of it, and being so settled that you do not have to defend your spot. God is already your defender. You are free to stop guarding yourself and start noticing other people.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Where do you feel the pressure to climb, to be picked, or to be seen?
2. What is the difference between thinking you are worthless and thinking of yourself less?
3. Who is someone you could put ahead of yourself this week in a way that costs you something small but real?

Then say this out loud. I do not compete for significance. I already carry it in Christ. I am secure enough to make room for other people.

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, my worth is already settled in You. Make me secure enough to put somebody else first today. Amen.

He Had Everything and Did Not Grab It

Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped.

PHILIPPIANS 2:5 TO 6

Paul does not say admire this mind. He does not say work your way up to it someday. He says have it. It is already yours in Christ Jesus. Then he shows you the only Person who ever had it perfectly.

So look at the picture. Jesus was God. Fully. Equal with the Father. And He did not treat that like a prize to clutch. The Greek word for grasped is *harpagmos*, which means something you seize and squeeze and refuse to release. Jesus did not white knuckle His rights. He opened His hand.

That means the mind Paul is asking you to carry did not start with you and it does not depend on your mood. It is a gift that came with belonging to Jesus. You are not trying to become humble enough to earn Him. You already have Him, so you can afford to be humble.

Jesus had every reason on earth and in heaven to hold on, and He let go. You are holding onto so much less.

μορφή (*morphe*), form, the essential nature of what something truly is

This is not a costume word. It is not about how something looks from the outside. *Morphe* points at the real substance underneath, not the costume on top. So when Paul says Jesus was in the *morphe* of God, he is not saying Jesus looked godlike. And the very next phrase settles it, because Paul says Jesus did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped. You cannot refuse to grab what you do not already have. Jesus was God. Not similar to God. Not a picture of God. God, in nature and essence. Hang onto that word, because in the very next verse Jesus takes the *morphe* of a servant. He did not stop being God. He took something new all the way into Himself.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. If the mind of Christ is already yours, what does that change about how hard you think you have to try?
2. What is something you tend to grab and hold tight, like credit, being right, or being first?
3. What would opening your hand actually look like for you tomorrow?

Then say this out loud. The mind of Christ is mine. I do not grab. I open my hand, because everything I really need is already given.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, You had everything and did not clutch it. Teach my hands to open the way Yours did. Amen.

The God Who Emptied Himself

but emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men.

PHILIPPIANS 2:7

Here is the sentence that should stop you cold. The One who spoke the stars into place emptied Himself. Not a little. All the way.

Look at how far down He went. Paul says He took the form of a *doulos*. That word does not mean a friendly assistant. It means a slave, the very bottom of the Roman world. No rights. No status. No protection. The God who made the law placed Himself under it. And He kept going, all the way to a cross, the death Rome saved for slaves and criminals because it was the most shameful way a person could die. He went there for a reason. Every wrong thing you have ever done, every lie and every cruel word, the Bible calls it sin, and He carried all of it Himself so it would not be counted against you. Three days later He walked out of the grave. Sin was paid for, and forgiveness was thrown wide open.

He did not trip and fall into this. Nobody pushed Him. Every single step down was a step He chose. Picture the most powerful ruler on earth standing up at a royal banquet, taking off his robe, tying a towel around his waist, and washing the feet of every servant in the room. Nobody in Rome could even process that image. Jesus did more than that, and He did it for you.

He was not pushed down. He stepped down. That is not weakness. It is the strongest thing anyone has ever done.

κενόω (*kenoo*), to empty, to pour out

This is the word behind the big theology term *kenosis*. Be careful with it, because it does not mean Jesus stopped being God. He never stopped, not for one second. What He set aside was the right to use His own power whenever He wanted for His own comfort. He chose to get hungry. He chose to get tired. He chose to cry at a friend's

funeral. He chose the slow road when He could have taken the instant one. He chose the cross when He could have called more than twelve legions of angels. He poured Himself out on purpose. Jesus did not lose His identity when He served. He showed it.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Why do you think Jesus chose the lowest place instead of the highest one?
2. How does it change things to know that nobody forced Jesus to do any of this?
3. Where is one low place you could step into this week on purpose, like helping with something nobody thanks you for?

Then say this out loud. My Jesus stepped down on purpose, and He did it for me. He did not lose His identity when He served. He showed it.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, thank You for going all the way down to come and get me. I never have to wonder whether You love me. Amen.

Down Before Up

Therefore God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the name that is above every name.

PHILIPPIANS 2:9

There is one word in this verse you cannot skip. Therefore. It ties everything behind it to everything in front of it. God did not lift Jesus up in spite of the cross. God lifted Him up because of the cross. The way down was never a detour. It was the whole mission.

And the name He was given is Lord. In Philippi that was a dangerous thing to say out loud. Caesar's face was on the money. Caesar's law ran the city. Caesar demanded the title Lord for himself. Paul writes to a Roman colony and says there is a Lord above Caesar, and one day Caesar himself will bow. Every knee. In heaven, on earth, and under the earth. Not some. Every.

Here is what I want you to carry out of this week. You do not get from verse 6 to verse 9 without going through verses 7 and 8. Down comes before up. Servant comes before Lord. Cross comes before crown. If the lowest place you have ever stood is the place you are standing right now, that is not the end of your story. God does not skip the valley. He transforms it. That lifting may not come this school year. It may not come in this life. But it comes, because He promised it and He has never missed. And you belong to the One who went down first.

Down before up. Servant before Lord. Cross before crown. The road has not changed, and you are walking it with Him.

ὑπερῷω (hyperupsoo), to lift up to the very highest place

This is two words joined together: hyper, meaning above and beyond, and hupsoo, meaning to lift up. Put them together and you get an exalting that runs right off the chart. God did not hand Jesus a promotion. God raised Him to a place no created being has ever stood. And here is the part that should get you. The scars are still in

His hands. The wounds were not erased when He was lifted. The humility was not a phase He grew out of. It was the very thing the exaltation was built on.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What does the word therefore tell you about how God works?
2. Is there a low place in your life right now that you have been treating like the end of the story?
3. If every knee will bow one day, what does that mean for whatever is scaring you this week?

Then say this out loud. Every knee will bow and every tongue will confess that Jesus Christ is Lord. That Lord is my Lord. The God who went all the way down is the God lifting me up.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, You are Lord over everything, and You are my Lord. Thank You that my low place is not my last place. Amen.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

**I have the mind of Christ. I do not grasp for status
and I do not compete for significance.**

**I choose the low place, because the God of the high
place has already claimed me.**

I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen.

Work It Out, Walk It Out

PHILIPPIANS 2:12 TO 30

God is already at work inside you, so you get to work it out instead of working for it, which means no more grumbling, real light in a dark room, and a life that goes all in for other people.

MEMORY VERSE

for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure.

PHILIPPIANS 2:13

Hey. This one is written just for you. Last week Jesus went all the way down. This week Paul takes that off the page and drops it into your Monday. Your kitchen. Your locker. The group chat. And you are going to meet two guys whose names are in the Bible forever for one reason: they went all in. Let's go.

Work It Out, Not Work For It

... work out your own salvation with fear and trembling, for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure.

PHILIPPIANS 2:12 TO 13

Read that slowly, because one small word changes everything. Paul says work out your salvation. He does not say work for it. Those are two completely different worlds. Nobody works for it. Jesus already finished that part, and Paul has spent this whole letter saying so.

The Greek word for work out is *katergazomai*. It means to work something all the way through until it is finished. The picture is a metalworker taking raw ore and hammering it into its finished shape. Here is the beautiful part of that picture. The metal is already metal. The smith did not create it. He works it until it becomes what it already was. God already put real salvation inside you. Now you get to cooperate with Him while He brings it all the way out.

And do not let the words fear and trembling scare you. Paul is not saying be afraid of God. He is saying take Him seriously. It is the feeling you get standing at the edge of the ocean. Not terror. Awe. You are handling something holy, and you know it.

So Christianity is not sitting back waiting for God to do everything while you do nothing. And it is not gritting your teeth doing everything yourself and hoping God is impressed. Paul kills both of those in one sentence. You are not the power source. You are the hands. The power is already flowing.

You are not manufacturing something God has to supply. You are cooperating with what He already started inside you.

ἐνεργέω (*energeo*), to work inside something, to energize, to activate from within

This is the word our word energy comes from. God is not standing across the room with His arms folded, waiting to see whether you can pull it off. He is on the inside. Paul says God works in you both

to will and to work, which means God is behind the wanting and behind the doing. He gives you the desire, then He gives you the power to move. And He is not annoyed about any of it. Paul says it is for His good pleasure. God genuinely enjoys working Himself out through your life.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is the difference between working for something and working it out?
2. Where have you been trying to be the power source instead of the hands?
3. What is one thing God has been nudging you toward that you could simply cooperate with this week?

Then say this out loud. God is working in me and I am working it out. I am not the power source. I am the hands, and the power is His.

PRAY TOGETHER

God, thank You that You are already at work inside me right now. Give me the wanting and the doing today. Amen.

Your Mouth Tells On Your Heart

Do all things without grumbling or disputing.

PHILIPPIANS 2:14

All things. Not most things. Not the easy things. Not just the stuff that goes your way. All things. That is a big ask, and Paul chose a very specific word to make it land.

Think about who he is pointing at. Israel walked out of Egypt through a sea that split open in front of them. They ate bread that fell out of the sky. They drank water that came out of a rock. And every single time the road got hard, they murmured. That whole generation never made it into the Promised Land. Hebrews tells us why. They did not believe God. The grumbling was the sound their unbelief made. Their mouths were telling on their hearts. Here is what this is not saying. God is not going to drop you for having a bad day. You are His. But what you say out loud shapes what you believe, so it is worth watching.

Here is why complaining is heavier than it feels. Every grumble is a tiny sermon that says God is not good, His plan is failing, and this hard thing right now is the final word. Not one of those three is true. You are not being told to fake a smile. Telling God honestly that something hurts is not grumbling. Half the Psalms do exactly that. Grumbling is talking about God instead of talking to Him. You are being invited to tell the truth about your God out loud, especially on the days that are hard.

Complaining is not a small habit. It is a sermon about God, preached with your own mouth, all day long.

γογγυσμός (gongusmos), grumbling, murmuring, complaining under your breath

This is not a random word for whining. It is the exact word the Greek Old Testament uses for Israel murmuring against Moses in the wilderness. Paul picks it on purpose. He is holding up an entire

chapter of history and saying do not repeat this one. The wilderness generation was one step away from everything God had promised them, and their murmuring showed a heart that would not trust Him. Words are not harmless. They aim your heart somewhere, and your heart follows.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is the thing you complain about the most without even noticing?
2. If every complaint is a sermon about God, what has your mouth been preaching lately?
3. What is one true thing about God you could say out loud the next time you want to grumble?

Then say this out loud. I do not grumble about what I cannot control, because I know Who controls all things.

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, catch me before the complaint gets out. Help me tell the truth about how good You are, even on a hard day. Amen.

Burn in the Dark

children of God without blemish in the midst of a crooked and twisted generation, among whom you shine as lights in the world.

PHILIPPIANS 2:15

Look at the order of that sentence, because Paul does not get it backwards. He calls you children of God first. Then he tells you to shine. You are not shining in order to become God's kid. You shine because you already are one. The light is not something you generate. It is something you carry.

A black hole does not glow. It swallows. Everything near it gets pulled into its gravity, and every room gets a little darker when it walks in. You have met people like that. Honestly, you have been that person on a bad day. A star is different. A star is surrounded by darkness too. It does not wait for the dark to leave before it burns. It burns right in the middle of the dark, and the dark cannot put it out.

So Paul is not telling you to go find a nicer room. He is telling you to shine in the room you are already standing in. The lunch table. The bus. The team. The house. You do not need the darkness to get easier. You need the Light in you to get clearer.

You do not wait for the dark to leave before you shine. Stars burn in the middle of it, and the dark cannot win.

φωστῆρες (phosteres), shining lights, the word used for the sun, the moon, and the stars

When Paul says you shine as lights, this is the word he reaches for. It is the same word the Greek Old Testament uses in Genesis 1 for the lights God hung in the sky. So Paul is not saying you are a tiny candle somebody has to shield from the wind. He is saying you are a star. God set you in one specific sky on purpose, and God did the hanging. Your job is not to manufacture light. Your job is to refuse to hide it.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Which comes first in that verse, being God's child or shining? Why does the order matter?
2. Where is the darkest room you walk into every week?
3. What is one small way you could burn there instead of blending in?

Then say this out loud. I am a child of God, so I shine. The darkness does not decide whether I burn. The Source in me does.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, You put me in this exact room on purpose. Make Your light in me clear today. Amen.

Timothy, the One Who Actually Cared

For I have no one like him, who will be genuinely concerned for your welfare. For they all seek their own interests, not those of Jesus Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 2:20 TO 21

Paul is sitting in Rome with a whole network of Christians around him. He needs to send somebody to Philippi who will genuinely care about those people. And then he says something that stings. They all seek their own interests. All. Not some. Not most. Every last one of them, except one guy.

Timothy was not the loudest person in the room. Paul does not brag about his talent or his preaching. Paul says Timothy has dokime, which means proven worth. Not potential. Not promise. Proven. That is the kind of quality you only find out about under pressure, never in the easy seasons. Anybody looks great on a good day. Timothy held up on the bad ones.

So here is an honest question, and it is not meant to shame you. It is meant to aim you. If Paul needed someone to send, someone he could trust to put other people first, to help without needing credit, to notice the kid nobody notices, would your name come up? You already have the mind of Christ. That is not something you earn today. It is something you get to use today.

Everyone in Rome was looking out for themselves. Timothy was looking out for you. That is the gospel with a face on it.

ἰσόψυχος (isopsuchos), equal souled, sharing the very same heart

This word shows up exactly one time in the entire New Testament, right here, and Paul used it about Timothy. It is two words joined together: isos, meaning equal, and psuche, meaning soul. Paul is not saying Timothy agreed with him about stuff. He is saying Timothy saw the world through the same eyes and carried the same weight on his heart. God noticed one young man who genuinely

cared when nobody else did, and He put that man's name in a letter that outlasted the empire. God always notices the Timothy.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Who is somebody in your life who cares about you without wanting anything back?
2. What is the difference between potential and proven? Where has your character been tested lately?
3. Who is one person this week you could care about with no credit and no audience?

Then say this out loud. I genuinely care about other people, because I carry the mind of Christ. God notices the ones who do.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, help me notice one person today who needs somebody to care, and then help me actually do something about it. Amen.

Epaphroditus Went All In

for he nearly died for the work of Christ, risking his life to complete what was lacking in your service to me.

PHILIPPIANS 2:30

Epaphroditus crossed a sea to bring a gift to Paul in prison. He got desperately sick doing it. He almost died. Then he got better, and here is the first thing he thought about: my friends back home heard I was sick and now they are worried, and I hate that they are worried. Read that again. Nearly dead, and already thinking about somebody else.

Paul stacks five titles on this man in a single sentence. Brother. Fellow worker. Fellow soldier. Your messenger. Minister to my need. In Rome, calling somebody your fellow soldier was the highest honor you could give a man. It meant this is the person who stood beside me when everything went wrong.

Two hundred years later a plague tore through the city of Alexandria in Egypt. Most people ran. They left the sick lying in the streets. A group of Christians did the opposite. They went door to door in the sickest parts of the city, nursed people, held hands, and buried the ones everybody else abandoned. People called them the *parabolani*, which means the ones who gamble, the same idea as the word Paul used for Epaphroditus. Watching them, the people around them could not explain it any other way than this: their God must be real.

Some faith watches from a safe distance. Epaphroditus closed the distance. You carry the same mind he did.

παραβολεύομαι (*paraboleuomai*), to gamble, to risk, to put yourself in danger on purpose

Like *isopsuchos*, this word appears only one time in the whole New Testament. Outside the Bible it was a gambling word. It meant shoving all your chips to the center of the table on one bet. Epaphroditus did not serve Jesus carefully from a safe distance. He

pushed everything in. He was not fearless. He was faithful, which is better. And notice this, because it matters. He did not actually die. He was simply willing to. That willingness is the whole testimony.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Where in your life have you been watching from a safe distance?
2. What is one thing you would be willing to risk being embarrassed about for Jesus?
3. Find one person at the edge of your normal circle who is carrying something heavy. What is one specific move you can make toward them before Sunday?

Then say this out loud. I close the distance. I do not watch from the sidelines. I go all in for Jesus, because He is worth everything I have.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, You went all in for me first. Make me brave enough to go where it costs something real. Amen.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

God is working in me and I am working it out.

**I shine as a light in a dark world, because the
Source in me cannot be put out.**

I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen.

All Things Loss

PHILIPPIANS 3:1 TO 11

Everything you could ever achieve is trash next to knowing Jesus, so you can stop climbing to be accepted and start receiving what He already finished.

MEMORY VERSE

Indeed, I count everything as loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord.

PHILIPPIANS 3:8

Hey. This one is written just for you. Paul had the best religious resume in history, and then he called all of it garbage. Why would anyone do that? By the end of this week, you will understand. Let's go.

Joy Is Your Armor

Finally, my brothers, rejoice in the Lord... and put no confidence in the flesh.

PHILIPPIANS 3:1 AND 3

You know how some kids only feel okay when they win, or when people like their post, or when they get the good grade? Paul flips that. He says rejoice in the Lord first, before anything goes right or wrong.

He knew hard things were coming for his friends. But he told them to be glad in Jesus first. Why? Because joy in the Lord is not a prize you get when life is easy. It is armor you wear when life gets hard. If your happiness depends on everything going your way, one bad day knocks you over. But if your joy is in Jesus, you stay standing.

Paul says God's people put no confidence in the flesh. That means we do not build our worth on what we do or how we look. We build it on who Jesus is. That is a foundation nothing can shake.

If your joy depends on everything going your way, one bad day knocks you over. If your joy is in Jesus, you stay standing.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What usually decides if you have a good day or a bad day?
2. What would change if your joy came from Jesus instead of your circumstances?
3. Where are you tempted to build your worth on what you do instead of who Jesus is?

Then say this out loud. My joy in Jesus is my armor. I do not need everything to go my way to stand strong. I build my worth on who Jesus is, not on what I do.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, be the reason I am glad today, before anything else goes right or wrong. Amen.

The Wrong Wall

If anyone else thinks he has reason for confidence in the flesh, I have more.

PHILIPPIANS 3:4

Paul had an incredible resume. The right family, the right training, the strictest rule keeping, a perfect record. If being religious were a competition, Paul would win every time.

Here is a picture of it. Imagine a man who climbs a ladder for forty years. He works harder than anyone. He reaches the very top. Then he looks around and realizes the ladder was leaning against the wrong wall the whole time. All that climbing, in the wrong direction.

That was Paul. He was the best climber there was, but the wall was wrong. Being good at religion is not a smaller version of being right with God. It is a totally different thing. You do not need to try harder to climb higher. You need a different wall, one only Jesus can build. Your good behavior is not the problem. Trusting your good behavior instead of trusting Jesus is the problem.

You do not need to climb higher. You need a different wall, one only Jesus can build.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What are you good at that you feel proud of? That is okay, it is a gift!
2. Have you ever thought God likes you more on your good days than your bad days?
3. Why is trusting Jesus different from just trying to be a good kid?

Then say this out loud. I will not climb the wrong wall. Being good is not the same as belonging to Jesus. I trust Jesus, not my own performance.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, I do not want to climb the wrong wall. Be my whole foundation. Amen.

Trash Compared to Treasure

Whatever gain I had, I counted as loss for the sake of Christ... and count them as rubbish, in order that I may gain Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 3:7 TO 8

After listing all his impressive stuff, Paul uses one shocking word to describe it. He calls it rubbish. Garbage. The stuff you scrape off your plate into the trash can.

Read that carefully, because Paul is not saying his hard work and his good record were bad things. He is saying that if you put them next to knowing Jesus, there is no comparison at all. It is like trading a bag of trash for a treasure chest and thinking you got robbed. You did not. You got everything.

Jesus plus nothing. He is the whole treasure. You do not have to be good enough before Jesus accepts you. He already gave Himself for you.

Next to Jesus, even your best trophies are just trash. He is the whole treasure.

σκύβαλα (skubala), garbage, trash, the scraps you throw out

It was a strong word, kind of a gross word, and Paul picked it on purpose. He is not saying his accomplishments were a little less valuable than Jesus. He is saying that next to knowing Jesus, all of it belongs in the trash can. Some teachers were saying, believe in Jesus and also keep all these extra rules, and then you will be good enough. Paul said no. Adding your own stuff to Jesus does not make the gospel better. It ruins it, like dropping garbage onto a delicious meal.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is something you are really proud of? How does it compare to knowing Jesus?
2. Why do you think Paul used such a strong, gross word on purpose?
3. Are you ever tempted to think you have to be good enough before Jesus accepts you?

Then say this out loud. Next to Jesus, my trophies are just trash.

Jesus plus nothing. He is the whole treasure. I do not add my works to His finished work.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, You are the treasure. Keep my hands from adding anything to what You already finished. Amen.

Found in Him

and be found in him, not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which comes through faith in Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 3:9

There are two kinds of right with God. One kind you make yourself by being good enough. The other kind is given to you as a gift through faith in Jesus. Paul wanted only the second kind.

Think of it like this. You could spend your whole allowance trying to buy a ticket to a place you can never afford. Or someone who loves you could just hand you the ticket, already paid for. Jesus paid for it with His own life. He took the punishment for your sin and handed you His own clean record. That is why the gift is free for you. Paul threw away the idea of earning his ticket. He said, I want to be found in Christ. That means when God looks at Paul, He sees Jesus.

This is the best news in the whole Bible. You are not accepted because of what you have done. You are accepted because of what Jesus has done. Your job is not to earn it. Your job is to receive it and say thank You.

You are not accepted because of what you have done. You are accepted because of what Jesus has done.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Have you ever tried to earn someone liking you? How did that feel?
2. What is the difference between earning God's love and receiving it as a gift?
3. What would change about how you feel if you really believed you are already found in Him?

Then say this out loud. I am found in Christ, not in my own goodness. God accepts me because of what Jesus did. I receive the gift. I do not earn it.

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, thank You that when You look at me You see Jesus. I receive it today instead of earning it. Amen.

Knowing Him, Not Just About Him

that I may know him and the power of his resurrection, and may share his sufferings.

PHILIPPIANS 3:10

Paul's biggest goal was not to know more facts about Jesus. It was to actually know Jesus Himself.

And here is something brave. Paul wanted the good part and the hard part of following Jesus. He wanted resurrection power, the amazing victory part. But he also wanted to share His sufferings, which means he was willing to do hard things for Jesus too. Most of us only want the easy part. Paul wanted all of Jesus.

You can know Jesus that closely. Talk to Him when things are great and when things are tough. You do not have to prove anything to Him. You are already His. And people who are settled like that are truly free.

You have nothing to prove because you are already His. Settled people are free people.

γινώσκω (ginosko), to know someone closely and personally

Not just knowing information about someone. You might know facts about a famous athlete, but you really know your best friend because you spend real time together. Paul wanted that kind of friendship with Jesus.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is the difference between knowing about Jesus and really knowing Him?
2. Are you only asking God for the easy stuff, or do you trust Him in the hard stuff too?
3. What is one real way you can spend time with Jesus this week?

Then say this out loud. I want to know Jesus Himself, not just know about Him. I trust Him in the easy and in the hard. I have nothing to prove because I am already His.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, I want to know You, not just know about You. Meet me today.
Amen.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Next to Jesus, my trophies are just trash. He is the whole treasure.

I am found in Christ, not in my own goodness, and I have nothing to prove.

I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen.

Press On: Citizens of Heaven

PHILIPPIANS 3:12 TO 21

You press on and live like heaven's citizen not to become His, but because Jesus already made you His own and is coming back for you.

MEMORY VERSE

But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 3:20

Hey. This one is written just for you. Paul says he is a runner who has not finished yet, and he tells us where he is really from. By the end of this week, you will know exactly who you are and where you are headed. Let's go.

Keep Pressing On

I press on to make it my own, because Christ Jesus has made me his own.

PHILIPPIANS 3:12

Paul wrote a huge part of the Bible, and he still said, I have not arrived yet. He was not done growing. He kept running toward Jesus.

You do not press on to make Jesus love you. He already does. You press on because you already belong to Him. That makes running fun, not scary.

You do not run to become His. You run because you already are His.

διώκω (dioko), to chase after, to pursue hard

This was the word for a hard, running pursuit. Not a slow walk, a real chase! But here is the cool part. Paul chases after Jesus because Jesus already caught him first. Jesus grabbed hold of Paul and would not let go. So Paul does not run to get Jesus' love. He runs because he already has it.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is something you are still getting better at?
2. How does it feel to know Jesus caught you first, before you did anything?
3. What does it mean to run because you already belong, not to try to belong?

Then say this out loud. I keep pressing on! Jesus already made me His own. I run because I belong to Him, not to earn Him.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, thank You for catching me first. Give me energy to keep running toward You today. Amen.

Don't Look Back

Forgetting what lies behind and straining forward to what lies ahead.

PHILIPPIANS 3:13

Real runners know a secret. The moment you turn your head to look behind you, your body twists and you slow down. Champions keep their eyes on the finish line.

Paul says forget what is behind. That does not mean he pretended his mistakes never happened. It means he would not let his past decide how fast he ran today. Not his failures. Not even his trophies. He left them all behind and kept reaching forward.

Maybe you messed up yesterday, or last year. That is real, but it is behind you. With Jesus, every day you get to face forward and run again.

Your past does not get to set your pace. Eyes forward. Keep running.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is one thing from the past that has been slowing you down?
2. Why is it just as tricky to get stuck on your wins as on your mistakes?
3. What would change if you ran today with your eyes forward?

Then say this out loud. I am not stuck in the past. I forget what is behind and I strain forward. My eyes are on Jesus.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, take the weight of yesterday off my shoulders. I face forward with You today. Amen.

Watch Who You Follow

Keep your eyes on those who walk according to the example you have in us.

PHILIPPIANS 3:17

You become like the people you watch the most. Paul said to keep your eyes on people who are really following Jesus, and copy how they live.

Think about how many people you watch every day on a screen. Some of them are running toward good things. Some are running the totally wrong way but make it look cool. You get to choose who you copy. Pick the ones who love Jesus and live it out.

You become like who you watch. So watch the right people.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Who are the people, real or online, you watch the most?
2. Are they running toward Jesus or away from Him?
3. Who is one person who loves Jesus that you could learn from on purpose?

Then say this out loud. I watch the right people. I follow those who follow Jesus. I choose my examples on purpose.

PRAY TOGETHER

God, give me eyes for the right examples and courage to follow them. Amen.

You Are a Citizen of Heaven

But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 3:20

When Paul wrote this, the city of Philippi was a Roman colony. That means the people there were citizens of Rome, even though Rome was far away. They followed Rome's rules and waited for news from their real home.

This does not mean you ignore earth. It means you live here carrying heaven's ways with you. You are not just from Cleburne. You are from heaven, on assignment here.

You are a citizen of heaven, deployed on earth. Live like it.

πολίτευμα (politeuma), citizenship, the place you really belong

Paul says your politeuma, your real citizenship, is in heaven. You live on earth right now, but you belong to heaven. Think of it like being an ambassador, someone sent to live in another country to represent their real home. You are heaven's ambassador, sent to your school, your team, your neighborhood.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What does it mean to be an ambassador for heaven at your school?
2. How might you act differently if you really remembered heaven is your home?
3. What is one place this week you can carry heaven's kindness into?

Then say this out loud. My real home is heaven. I am an ambassador of the King, sent to earth on purpose. I carry heaven wherever I go.

PRAY TOGETHER

King Jesus, I represent Your kingdom today. Help me carry heaven into every room I walk into. Amen.

Your King Is Coming Back

[Jesus] will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body, by the power that enables him even to subject all things to himself.

PHILIPPIANS 3:21

Here is the best news. Your King is coming back. And when He comes, He is going to change your body to be like His glorious body, the same kind of body Jesus had when He walked out of the tomb on Easter.

That is not a make believe spiritual idea. It is a real, brand new body that never gets sick, never gets tired, and never dies. And the power that does it is the same power that holds the whole universe together. Nothing is too hard for the King who is coming for you.

So keep going. Keep your eyes forward. Remember you belong to heaven. Your King is on His way, and the finish line is worth it.

The same power that raised Jesus from the dead is going to raise you. Hold on. Press on.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. How does knowing Jesus is coming back change how you live today?
2. Why is it good news that the resurrection is a real, physical thing?
3. What is one way you can press on this week while you wait for the King?

Then say this out loud. My King is coming back! He will make me brand new by His mighty power. I press on, I keep my eyes forward, and I belong to heaven.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, thank You that You are coming back for me. Keep my eyes forward until You do. Amen.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

**I press on, because Jesus already made me His
own.**

**My citizenship is in heaven and my King is coming
back for me.**

I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen.

The Settled Heart

PHILIPPIANS 4:1 TO 23

A heart settled in Jesus stays guarded by peace, chooses what fills its mind, and is content whether it has a little or a lot.

MEMORY VERSE

And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.

PHILIPPIANS 4:7

Hey. This one is written just for you. Paul is finishing his letter from a prison cell, and he lands the whole thing on one thing: a heart that stays settled no matter what is going on around it. By the end of this week you will know how peace guards you and how to be okay whether you have a little or a lot. Let's go.

Worth the Awkward Conversation

Therefore, my brothers, whom I love and long for, my joy and crown, stand firm thus in the Lord, my beloved. I entreat Euodia and I entreat Syntyche to agree in the Lord.

PHILIPPIANS 4:1 TO 2

Two women in Paul's church, Euodia and Syntyche, were in a fight. It got so big that Paul heard about it all the way in a prison cell in another country. So Paul says their names out loud in a letter the whole church would read, and he asks them to make it right.

Maybe you know how that feels. A friend at school stops talking to you. Somebody said something and now it is weird between you. It is way easier to just avoid them. But Paul says fixing it is worth the awkward conversation.

Notice this. Paul does not tell them to just agree with each other. He tells them to agree in the Lord. You do not have to like all the same stuff to be one. You just have to love the same Jesus and let Him be the center.

Fixing a friendship is worth the awkward conversation. Unity is worth going first.

στέφανος (stephanos), a victor's crown, a winner's wreath

In Philippians 4:1 Paul calls his church his joy and crown. The word is stephanos, the leafy crown they put on the head of the winner after a race. Paul is saying these people are his prize, his trophy. That is why the fight bothered him so much. When people who love Jesus stay split apart, it hurts the whole team. Being one is worth going first to fix things.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. Is there someone you are kind of in a fight with right now?
2. Why is it easier to avoid a person than to fix things with them?
3. What is one brave, kind thing you could say to make it right?

Then say this out loud. I am a peacemaker. I do not run from hard conversations. I go first to make things right, and I agree in the Lord.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, give me the courage to go first with the person I have been avoiding. Amen.

Peace That Stands Guard

Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.

PHILIPPIANS 4:6 TO 7

Ever lie in bed and your brain will not stop? A test tomorrow. Something you said that came out wrong. Something at home that feels scary. That worried, spinning feeling has a name in the Bible, and Paul says you do not have to carry it.

He does not just say stop worrying. That never works. He says trade it. Every single worry, hand it to God in prayer. And add thank you. Then watch what God sends back.

This peace is bigger than your brain can explain. Even when nothing about the problem has changed yet, the peace shows up and stands guard. You did not build it. God sent it. Not as a prize for praying well, but because that is what He does with what you hand Him.

Trade your worry for prayer. God answers with peace that stands guard like soldiers.

φρουρέω (phroureo), to guard, like soldiers standing watch

In Philippians 4:7 Paul says God's peace will guard your heart. The word is phroureo, and it is an army word. It means a group of soldiers standing guard at the gate of a city, keeping out anything that tries to attack. So God's peace is not just a calm feeling. It is like armed soldiers standing watch over your heart and mind. Worry knocks on the door, and it finds guards there.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is one thing you have been worried about lately?
2. What would it look like to actually pray about it instead of just worrying?
3. Why is it powerful to say thank you to God even before the problem is fixed?

Then say this out loud. I do not have to carry worry. I hand it all to God, and His peace stands guard over my heart like soldiers at the gate.

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, here is my worry. I am handing it over right now, and I say thank You before anything changes. Amen.

You Choose What Fills the Room

Whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is just, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is commendable... think about these things.

PHILIPPIANS 4:8

Think of your mind like a room. Every video you watch, every song, every game, every thing people say about you, all of it walks into that room. And here is the truth Paul wants you to know: you get to choose what fills it.

If you feed your mind stuff that is mean, fake, or scary, your mind starts to feel mean, fake, and scary. If you feed it what is true and good and lovely, your mind starts to settle down. What goes in is what grows.

Your brain will drift to the worst thing on its own if you let it. So do not let it. On purpose, aim your mind at what is true and good. You are the one who decides what fills your room.

What you feed your mind is what grows. Choose the good stuff on purpose.

λογίζομαι (logizomai), to think, to count carefully, like doing math

When Paul says think about these things, the word is logizomai. It is a math word. It means to carefully add something up, like a person counting money on purpose, not just glancing at it. So Paul is not saying let good thoughts drift by. He is saying choose them on purpose, count them, focus on them like they matter. Because they do.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is something you watch or scroll that leaves you feeling worse?
2. What is something true and good you could fill your mind with instead?
3. How is choosing your thoughts like doing math on purpose?

Then say this out loud. I choose what fills my mind. I aim my thoughts at what is true and good on purpose, and I win the battle for my room.

PRAY TOGETHER

God, help me aim my mind on purpose today instead of letting it drift. Amen.

The Secret Nobody Can Take

I have learned, in whatever situation I am, to be content... I can do all things through him who strengthens me.

PHILIPPIANS 4:11 AND 13

You have probably seen verse 13 on a shirt or a poster. I can do all things through him who strengthens me. A lot of people think it means Jesus will help you win a game or ace a test. But look at the verses right before it. Paul is talking about something way deeper.

Paul says he learned to be okay when he had almost nothing, and okay when he had plenty. That is the secret. And here is the surprise: having a lot is actually the harder test. When you finally get the new phone or the new shoes, you feel great for about a week, and then you want the next thing. Stuff never fills you up all the way.

So I can do all things really means: with Jesus, I can be settled and okay whether I have a little or a lot. That is a secret the richest kid at school cannot buy and the poorest kid cannot lose.

Contentment is not about how much you have. It is about Who you have. And that is Jesus.

αὐτάρκης (autarkes), content, having enough, full up

The word for content is autarkes. It means having enough, being full, not needing anything else to be okay. Smart teachers in Paul's day said you make this feeling yourself by being tough. Paul says no. He does not make it. He receives it from Jesus who lives inside him. That is why nobody can take it. It is not about what you own. It is about who owns you.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is something you really want right now? Would it truly make you happy forever?
2. Why is having a lot sometimes harder than having a little?
3. What does it mean that your enough comes from Jesus, not from stuff?

Then say this out loud. My enough comes from Jesus, not from stuff. Whether I have a little or a lot, I am settled and okay through the One who strengthens me.

PRAY TOGETHER

Jesus, You are my enough. Settle my heart when I start wanting the next thing. Amen.

God Supplies, and Nothing Can Stop Him

... no church entered into partnership with me in giving and receiving, except you only... And my God will supply every need of yours according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus.

PHILIPPIANS 4:15 AND 19

The Philippians gave to help Paul when nobody else would. So Paul makes them a promise: God will take care of everything they truly need. Not from a little bank account, but out of God's riches in glory. God's supply never runs out. It has no bottom.

Notice it says every need, not every want. God is a good Father. A good dad does not buy his kid everything they point at. He gives them exactly what they really need, right on time.

And here is the wildest part. At the very end, Paul says hi from believers in Caesar's household. Caesar was the most powerful man in the world, and he had Paul in chains. But the message about Jesus snuck right into the emperor's own palace. The chains meant to stop Jesus' message became the road it traveled on.

God supplies every need out of riches that never run out. And nothing, not even Caesar, can stop His message.

κοινωνέω (koinoneo), to partner with, to team up, to share life together

In Philippians 4:15 Paul says no church entered into partnership with him except the Philippians. That verb is koinoneo, and the noun form is koinonia. It means partnership, being on the same team, sharing what you have. The Philippians did not just watch Paul from far away. They jumped in and shared his troubles with him. When God's people team up like that, amazing things happen. That is how the good news kept spreading.

DO TOGETHER

Journal it. Answer these three, out loud or in a notebook.

1. What is the difference between something you need and something you just want?
2. How does it feel to know God's supply never runs out?
3. If the message about Jesus reached a palace, where is one place you could share it?

Then say this out loud. My God supplies my every need from riches that never run out. Nothing can stop what He is doing, and I am part of His team.

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, thank You that Your supply never runs out. I trust You with what I need today. Amen.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

**I hand every worry to God, and His peace stands
guard over my heart.**

**My enough comes from Jesus, and nothing can stop
what God is doing.**

I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen.
